Praise of the Ultimate

Paramārthastava · Toh 1122 · Derge Tengyur
དཀོ་དམ་པར་བསྟོད་པ

Praise of the Ultimate, known in Sanskrit as the Paramārthastava and in Tibetan as Döndampar Töpa, is a short hymn in verse attributed to the master Nāgārjuna and traditionally counted among his Four Hymns (Catuḥstava). It praises the Buddha from the standpoint of ultimate truth by way of negation: the Protector is unborn and without abode, neither an entity nor a non-entity, beyond color, shape, and measure, neither saṃsāra nor nirvāṇa, so that the hymn finally asks who, when all phenomena are empty, is praised and by whom. In eleven verses it joins devotion to the Madhyamaka teaching of emptiness, praising through the world's conventional designations what lies beyond the reach of speech. The text is Toh 1122 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra), and it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the Tibetan translator Tsultrim Gyalwa.

In the language of India: paramaarthastavaṃ. In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Ultimate.

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

You who are unborn and without abode,
Who utterly transcend the analogies of the world,
Who are not a domain that speech can express:
Protector, how shall I praise you?

Yet even so, in whatever way,
Relying on the world's designations
For you whose domain is the meaning of suchness,
With great reverence I praise you.

Through your unborn nature,
You have no birth at all.
Protector, you have no going and no coming:
To you who have no entity, I pay homage and bow.

You are not a non-entity, nor are you an entity;
You are not annihilated, nor are you eternal;
You are not impermanent, nor are you permanent:
To you who have no duality, I pay homage and bow.

You are not red, nor green, nor crimson;
You are not yellow, nor black, nor white;
No color whatsoever is perceived in you:
To you who have no color, I pay homage and bow.

You are not large, nor are you small;
You are neither long nor round;
You have attained the reality of the immeasurable:
To you who have no measure, I pay homage and bow.

You are not far, nor are you near;
You are not the sky, nor are you the ground;
You are not saṃsāra, nor are you nirvāṇa:
To you who have no abode, I pay homage and bow.

Because you abide in no phenomenon at all,
You have become the very reality of the sphere of phenomena (dharmadhātu),
And have attained supreme profundity:
To you, the profound one, I pay homage and offer praise.

With such a praise as this, are you praised?
Or else, what here is praised?
When all phenomena are empty,
Who is praised, and by whom?

You who have entirely abandoned birth and destruction,
In whom there is neither extreme nor middle,
Who have neither apprehended object nor apprehending subject:
Who here is able to praise you?

Through the merit of praising the Sugata (the One Gone to Bliss),
Who has neither going nor coming,
Who has abandoned going,
May the worlds go to the abode of the Sugata.

The Praise of the Ultimate, composed by the master, the noble Nāgārjuna, is complete.

It was translated, edited, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Kṛṣṇa Paṇḍita and the translator, the monk Tsultrim Gyalwa.

Translator's Notes

• In the seventh stanza the text reads □□□, which makes no sense here; I have translated the evident reading □□□□, "near," the counterpart of "far." In the eighth stanza the text reads □□□□□□□□□ ("the profound two"), a syllable the edition marks as variant; I have followed the evident reading □□□□□□□□, "profundity." In the seventh stanza □□□□ is the verse abbreviation of □□□□□□, saṃsāra, paired with nirvāṇa, not "retinue." The closing stanza plays on going: the Sugata, "the One Gone to Bliss," has neither gone nor come and has abandoned going (Skt. gati, which also means a destiny of rebirth), and the merit is dedicated so that the worlds may go to his abode.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.